Sporting Jax Winter Invitational

Jacksonville / St Johns County, Florida · January 23–24, 2027

Savannah United 17/18B & 16/17B — U9 Premier · U9 Blue · U10 Premier · U10 Blue

One guide covers all four squads. Where a team differs (bracket, coach on the sideline, game times) it is marked **Pending Confirmation** until the schedule drops.

1. Tournament Quick Start

Event	Sporting Jax Winter Invitational OFFICIAL TOURNAMENT INFORMATION
Dates	Saturday January 23 – Sunday January 24, 2027
Location	Jacksonville / St Johns County, Florida
Age groups	Competitive U8–U14, boys and girls. Our squads play U9 and U10.
Format for us	7v7 · 25-minute halves · unlimited substitutions
Entry fee	U8–U10: $800, plus a $20 per-team GotSport processing fee
Registration deadline	January 10, 2027 (team entry is handled by the club, not by parents)
Stay-to-play	Yes — housing through the tournament's official agent (see section 6)
Drive	Savannah → Jacksonville/St Johns: about 2 h 05, roughly 130 miles (see section 5)
Fields	PENDING CONFIRMATION Field assignments are published with the schedule.

2. Parent Action Items

CONFIRMED TEAM INFORMATION **Do this now**

- ☐ Tell your team manager by **December 15** whether your player is available that weekend.
- ☐ Do not book a hotel on your own — this event is stay-to-play and outside bookings can disqualify a team.
- ☐ Check that your player's 2026-27 medical release and player pass are current with the club.

PENDING CONFIRMATION **Once the schedule is released (expected a few weeks out)**

- ☐ Confirm your exact report time and field for each game.
- ☐ Book the team hotel through the official housing link (section 6) as soon as it is published.
- ☐ Plan Saturday lunch around the gap between games once times are known.

PARENT MANAGER RECOMMENDATION **Before leaving home**

- ☐ Both kits packed (white and blue), plus a spare pair of socks.
- ☐ Layers for a cool morning and warm afternoon — January in north Florida is mild, not hot.
- ☐ Water bottles filled, snacks for between games, camp chairs in the car.

3. What We Know vs What We're Waiting On

CONFIRMED

- Dates: Jan 23–24, 2027
- City/region: Jacksonville / St Johns County, FL
- U9–U10 play 7v7, 25-minute halves
- Entry accepted at club level; deadline Jan 10
- Stay-to-play through the official agent
- Tournament rules are published and final (section 13)
- Contact: info@SportingJaxAcademy.com · 904-257-5575

WAITING ON

- Which complex and which fields
- Game times, opponents, bracket shape
- Official hotel list and team rate
- Parking and check-in instructions
- Uniform colour per game
- Whether U9 and U10 play separate brackets

4. Tournament Overview

Sporting Jax Soccer Academy hosts this event each January for competitive U8–U14 teams from across the southeast. It runs on a GotSport platform, so registration, brackets and the published schedule all live in one place.

- **Official tournament page** — sportingjaxacademy.com/WinterInvitational (registration, schedule, field layout, hotels)
- **Official rules (2027 FINAL)** — the Google Doc linked from the tournament page; section 13 below summarises what affects us
- **Registration** — GotSport event page, linked from the tournament site

Note the name: the club's own calendar lists this weekend as "Florida Elite Winter Invitational", which is the academy's former brand. The 2027 event page says **Sporting Jax Winter Invitational** — same club, same weekend. Use the Sporting Jax name when you register or call the tournament.

5. Travel & Arrival Planning

Savannah to the Jacksonville / St Johns area is a straightforward run down I-95 South. Times below are to the general tournament area — add time once the specific complex is announced.

Conditions	**Best case** 1 h 55 · **Normal** 2 h 05 · **Heavy (Friday evening, holiday traffic)** 2 h 40
Route	I-95 S toward Jacksonville, exit for the St Johns / Baymeadows area depending on the assigned complex
Player report time	PENDING CONFIRMATION Tournament rules request teams be present 30 minutes before kickoff; coaches typically ask for 45. Plan for 45 until your coach confirms.
Depart by	Work backwards from report time, not kickoff: report time minus 2 h 15 (drive plus parking and walk-in)
Overnight	Recommended — a single-day round trip on Saturday makes the second game miserable. See section 6.

6. Lodging & Stay-to-Play

OFFICIAL TOURNAMENT INFORMATION **This is a stay-to-play event.** The 2027 rules (section 23) require all teams to book through the official housing agent, Traveling Teams, and say a team that refuses may be disqualified. Rule 2e applies the requirement to teams travelling **more than 80 miles** from their home field; the tournament web page says **90 miles**. Savannah United's home field is roughly 130 miles away, so the requirement applies to us under either number. We are following the stricter reading (80 miles) and the club is confirming it with the housing agent.

PENDING CONFIRMATION **Hotel list and team rate**

The tournament links its hotel programme through a GotSport housing store, which publishes the approved properties and rates as the event approaches. That list is not yet populated, and the tournament page still shows brackets and schedule as "coming soon".

- Do **not** book outside the programme, even at a better rate.
- Your team manager will circulate the approved list with the team rate and a booking deadline as soon as it is live.
- Anything you find elsewhere is listed as information only, never as a recommendation.

PARENT MANAGER RECOMMENDATION

- Book the moment the link goes live — January is a busy weekend in Jacksonville and the approved block is finite.
- Ask for two beds if you are sharing a room with a player; the block sometimes defaults to a king.
- Prioritise drive time to the complex over hotel frills. With two games in a day, 15 minutes each way matters more than a pool.

7. Weather Planning

PARENT MANAGER RECOMMENDATION

Late January in north Florida is mild and changeable: mornings can sit in the 40s–50s °F, afternoons commonly reach the 60s, and rain is always possible. This is **not** a heat tournament — plan for layers and wind, not heat illness.

- Check the forecast within 72 hours of travel and again the night before.
- Pack a warm layer for the first game and a change of socks for wet grass.
- Lightning protocol: the tournament stops play for lightning and applies its own delay rules (section 13).

No forecast is stated here this far out — anything beyond seven days would be invented.

8. Venue, Parking, Fields & Amenities

PENDING CONFIRMATION The tournament assigns complexes after brackets are built. U8–U12 sides play within the Jacksonville / St Johns County area; the specific park, field numbers and parking instructions come with the published schedule and field layout.

- Field layout: linked from the tournament page as a live, updated map (Canva-hosted).
- Parking: not yet published. Expect paid or park-and-walk arrangements at larger complexes and plan to arrive early.
- Amenities: restrooms and concessions are typical at these complexes; nothing verified yet for our specific site.

We do not publish our own map — only the tournament's official field layout, once it is live.

9. Team Communication Plan

Official schedule, brackets, scores	GotSport event page
Team updates and changes	PlayMetrics messages / team email
Tournament logistics, hotels	Your team manager
Soccer questions, availability	Coach Keith Gunn
Day-of urgent changes	Team chat, then the manager directly

10. Coach Updates

PENDING CONFIRMATION

This section will be updated once the coaches release arrival times, uniform assignments and any team-specific instructions. Nothing here is invented: if you have not heard it from a coach or the manager, it is not a team instruction.

11. Guidance for Our Players (U9 / U10)

These are young players at their first or second winter travel event. The goal is a good experience, not a perfect performance.

- Protect sleep the two nights before; a tired nine-year-old plays badly and remembers it.
- Keep meals familiar and simple, and eat a proper breakfast even when the game is early.
- Water before thirst, small sips often, especially between games.
- Limit running around between games — a park is tempting, but two matches in a day adds up.
- Pack something quiet for downtime, and a dry change of clothes.
- Expect big feelings after a loss. Keep the car ride home short on analysis and long on food.
- Let the coaches coach. Sideline instruction from parents usually confuses this age group.

12. Packing Checklist

Player gear

- ☐ Both kits (white and blue)
- ☐ Cleats and shin guards
- ☐ Two spare pairs of socks
- ☐ Warm-up layer / jacket
- ☐ Dry clothes for after
- ☐ Labeled water bottle
- ☐ Personal medication
- ☐ Player pass and medical release (if the club hands them to you)

Parent sideline

- ☐ Camp chairs
- ☐ Blanket or throw for a cold morning
- ☐ Snacks for between games
- ☐ Water and a thermos
- ☐ Rain jacket or umbrella
- ☐ Portable charger
- ☐ Wet-wipe pack and a trash bag for muddy gear
- ☐ Cash for parking or concessions

13. Tournament Rules Parents Need

OFFICIAL TOURNAMENT INFORMATION — 2027 RULES FINAL

Game length (U9/U10)	25-minute halves, 5-minute half-time
Format (U9/U10)	7v7 · maximum roster 12 · up to 3 guest players
Heading	**Not allowed** for U12 and younger — an indirect free kick is awarded
Offside	U9–U10 have one referee who may call obvious offside; no build-out lines in any age group
Substitutions	Unlimited, at the referee's discretion at any stoppage
Mercy rule	Match ends at an 8-goal differential (immediately in the second half, at half-time if reached in the first)
Water breaks	Mandatory at the midpoint of each half when the temperature is expected to reach 85 °F
Forfeits	A team not ready within 5 minutes forfeits 4-0; teams are asked to be present 30 minutes before kickoff
Ejections	Automatic one-game suspension minimum, player or coach
Championship ties	Straight to penalty kicks
Weather	A match stopped after half-time is final at that score; no guaranteed refunds for weather
Recording	Cameras only on the spectator side, never the player/coach side

Six-tier tiebreaker (in order)

1. Head-to-head result
2. Net goal differential, maximum 4 per game
3. Most goals scored, maximum 6 per game
4. Fewest goals allowed, no maximum
5. Most shutouts
6. Penalty kicks per FIFA

In crossover brackets, head-to-head is ignored when the tied teams did not all play each other equally.

14. Nearby Family Resources

PENDING CONFIRMATION Restaurants, sporting-goods stores and urgent care within easy reach of the hotel depend on which complex we are assigned. That list will be added with the hotel block rather than guessed now.

15. Weekend Itinerary

Friday, Jan 22	Travel day if we stay over. Check in at the team hotel, early dinner, early night. PENDING whether the team travels Friday or Saturday morning.
Saturday, Jan 23	Group play. Game times and field assignments pending. Expect two matches with a gap for lunch.
Sunday, Jan 24	Knockout or final rounds depending on Saturday's results. Travel home afterwards.

16. Quick Reference — Screenshot This

Sporting Jax Winter Invitational · Jan 23–24, 2027

Jacksonville / St Johns County, FL · 7v7 · 25-min halves

Stay-to-play: official housing agent only

Rules: heading banned U12 and under · no build-out lines · 8-goal mercy

Tournament: info@SportingJaxAcademy.com · 904-257-5575

Fields, times and hotels: pending — check the app and team messages

17. Next Steps

1. **By December 15** — confirm your player's availability with the team manager.
2. **When the hotel link goes live** — book inside the official block, two beds if sharing.
3. **When the schedule publishes** — note report times, fields and uniform colour; plan the Saturday gap.
4. **Week of the event** — check the forecast, pack layers, and confirm departure time with your coach.

We will update this guide as each piece lands — the app and this document are generated from the same information, so they cannot disagree. If something here is still pending and you need it sooner, ask your team manager rather than assuming.

Prepared with Bob Team Manager · Version 1.0 · Updated November 13, 2026 · Official facts from sportingjaxacademy.com/WinterInvitational and the 2027 Winter Invitational Rules FINAL